The Noble Dhāraṇī Called Certainty

Āryaniścayanāmadhāraṇī · Toh 977 · Derge Kangyur
འཕགས་པ་གདོན་མི་ཟ་བ་ཞེས་བྱ་བའི་གཟུངས།

The Noble Dhāraṇī Called Certainty, known in Sanskrit as the Āryaniścayanāmadhāraṇī and in Tibetan as 'phags pa gdon mi za ba zhes bya ba'i gzungs, is a short dhāraṇī scripture in which the Buddha offers protection through the recitation of a spell. The teaching is set at Vaiśālī, in the Peaked Hall on the bank of the Markaṭa pond, where Śakra, lord of the gods, tells the Blessed One that he is being attacked and harassed by the asuras, his longstanding enemies. He asks for a teaching that will bring him lasting benefit and happiness. In response, the Buddha gives him a vidyā-mantra, which he calls his own heart essence, named Certainty. The work is Toh 977 in the Kangyur, where it belongs to the class of dhāraṇī texts, the collections of protective and empowering incantations attributed to the Buddha.

In the language of India: ārya niścaya nāma dhāraṇī. In the language of Tibet: The Noble Dhāraṇī Called Certainty.

Homage to all the buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear at one time. The Blessed One was dwelling at Vaiśālī, in the Peaked Hall on the bank of the Markaṭahrada. At that time Śakra, lord of the gods, said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, the asuras attack and harass me. The asuras and I have long been unfriendly and have become enemies. Therefore, Blessed One, I beg you, by whatever means, to teach me such a Dharma as will bring me lasting benefit and happiness."

When he had made this request, the Blessed One spoke to Śakra, lord of the gods: "For that reason, Kauśika, take up this vidyā-mantra, my heart essence, called Certainty:

tadyathā urbaba nirbi sirbi urburbure hūle hūme dikhume pratyaṃgama āgaccha mahāmayūri nāma

Protect, protect me and all my retinue from all fears and all harms!

sarva kāya vāga mana ścarite svāhā"

When the Blessed One had spoken thus with delight, Śakra, lord of the gods, was overjoyed. He rejoiced in what the Blessed One had said, bowed his head at the Blessed One's feet, and vanished from that very place.

This completes the noble dhāraṇī called Certainty.

Translator's Notes

• The Tibetan title word here means "certainty" or "unfailing," matching the Sanskrit niścaya. It is not the term for a seizing spirit (graha), so the glossary sense of that word does not apply. The Tibetan sentence asking for protection could also be read as "protect me, together with all my retinue, from all fears and all harms." The sense is the same either way. The Monkey Pond is given by its Sanskrit name, Markaṭahrada, "Monkey Pond." The Peaked Hall, Sanskrit Kūṭāgāraśālā, is kept in its descriptive English form.

Colophon

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Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.